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THE RED SEA AND THE GULF OF ADEN

MARITIME THREAT ASSESSMENT

War risk to merchant shipping following the Houthi blockade of Saudi Arabia

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Overview

The Red Sea has entered its most dangerous phase for merchant shipping since the Houthi campaign began in late 2023. Following the effective closure of the Strait of Hormuz earlier in 2026, and the Houthi declaration of a naval blockade of Saudi Arabia in mid-July, the two principal maritime routes serving Gulf and Saudi crude exports are now under simultaneous threat. In the space of a fortnight in late July, Saudi-flagged tankers were struck in the southern Red Sea, Aramco energy infrastructure at Jizan and Yanbu was hit for the first time in more than four years, and war risk premiums for southern Red Sea voyages rose from around 0.3 per cent of hull value to over 1 per cent.

Trident assesses the war risk to Saudi-flagged, owned or operated vessels, and to vessels calling at Saudi Red Sea ports, as **SEVERE**, with a **CRITICAL** risk to Saudi-affiliated tankers transiting the Bab el-Mandeb and the southern Red Sea approaches. The risk to shipping with no Saudi, Israeli, US or UK affiliation is lower but not negligible, given the demonstrated potential for mistaken-identity attacks.

The escalation of July 2026

The current crisis is the product of two converging pressures. The first is the closure of the Strait of Hormuz, effectively shut since late February 2026, which forced Saudi Arabia to route substantially all of its functioning crude exports through the East-West (Petroline) pipeline to the Red Sea coast at Yanbu. By June 2026 this corridor was carrying around 4.1 million barrels per day, with Yanbu loadings reaching a record 4.7 million barrels per day in mid-July. The second is the Houthi decision to open a front against this corridor.

On 20 July 2026 the Houthis declared a naval blockade of Saudi Arabia and announced their intention to target Saudi-linked vessels. The declaration was followed within days by action:

Date	Event
20 Jul 2026	Houthi naval blockade of Saudi Arabia declared. Indicative war risk premiums rose from around 0.3% to around 0.75% of hull value.
22 Jul 2026	Saudi-flagged tanker Encelia struck by projectile southwest of Al Shuqaiq after departing Yanbu; fire on the starboard side, crew safe, no pollution. Houthis also claimed a strike on the Bahri VLCC Layla, which remains independently unconfirmed.
23 Jul 2026	Premiums for southern Red Sea voyages rose above 1% of hull value. Brent crude closed at its highest since May.
24 Jul 2026	Saudi-operated tanker NCC Masa sustained hull damage in the Red Sea but continued to destination. Saudi-led coalition struck Houthi-held Hodeidah.
25 Jul 2026	Houthis struck Saudi Aramco energy facilities at Jizan and Yanbu with ballistic and cruise missiles and drones. Aramco suspended operations at the Jizan refinery.
29 Jul 2026	Joint War Committee issued JWLA-034, adding the ports and coastal waters of Saudi Arabia and Eritrea to the Listed Areas and moving the Red Sea notification line around 800 km north to cover Jeddah and Yanbu.

The insurance response: JWLA-034 and premiums

The war risk insurance market responded quickly and its response is a useful, independent barometer of how underwriters read the threat. Two developments matter.

The Listed Area has expanded north



On 29 July 2026 the Joint War Committee (the joint Lloyd's Market Association and International Underwriting Association body that maintains the Hull War, Piracy, Terrorism and Related Perils Listed Areas) issued circular JWLA-034. It added the ports and coastal waters, to 12 nautical miles offshore, of Saudi Arabia and Eritrea to the Listed Areas, and moved the Red Sea notification line around 800 km north. The practical effect is that calls at the northern Saudi ports of Jeddah and Yanbu, previously outside the enhanced-risk zone, now attract additional war risk premium and require notice to underwriters. The revised areas took effect on war risk policies from 8 to 12 August 2026.

A vessel entering a Listed Area does not automatically pay more, since rating is a matter for negotiation between owner and underwriter, but the designation is the trigger for additional premium and for the seven-day cancellation-and-review mechanism built into war risk cover. The northward move signals that underwriters now price the whole Saudi Red Sea coast, not merely the southern approaches, as a war zone.

Premiums have risen several-fold

Indicative additional war risk premiums for southern Red Sea voyages moved from around 0.3 per cent of hull value before the blockade to around 0.75 per cent immediately after the declaration, and above 1 per cent following the tanker strikes. For a large tanker this equates to hundreds of thousands of dollars in additional cost for a single seven-day transit, before any breach-of-warranty or additional-premium considerations for calls at newly-listed ports. Pricing for Saudi-affiliated vessels and for voyages involving southern ports such as Jizan and Al Shuqaiq has risen most sharply, in some cases to several times pre-crisis levels.

The Houthi threat and target profile

The Houthi movement has demonstrated, since 2023, a layered maritime strike capability combining anti-ship ballistic and cruise missiles, one-way attack drones, uncrewed surface vessels and, on occasion, small-boat operations. The July 2026 strikes on the Encelia and NCC Masa, and the missile and drone salvos against Jizan and Yanbu, confirm that this capability remains intact and can reach both moving vessels in the southern Red Sea and fixed infrastructure on the Saudi coast.

For owners and operators, the operative question is not the breadth of the capability but the targeting logic, because that determines which vessels are exposed. On the current evidence the target profile is defined by affiliation, not by vessel type.

Primary target set

The declared and demonstrated priority is Saudi-affiliated shipping. Following the blockade declaration, maritime security assessments placed the following at high risk of Houthi attack:

- Saudi Arabia-flagged, owned, managed or operated vessels.
- Vessels on a voyage to or from Saudi Arabia, and vessels calling at Saudi Red Sea ports.
- Tankers associated with Saudi crude and product exports, in particular those loading at or having recently departed Yanbu, Jizan and the southern terminals.

The vessels struck in the opening phase fit this profile precisely. The Encelia is a Saudi-flagged product tanker that had loaded at Yanbu; NCC Masa and the claimed targets Layla and NCC Ghazal are Saudi-flagged or Saudi-operated tankers. The Houthi justification in each case was that the vessel had “violated the blockade” of Saudi ports.

The residual Israel, US and UK target set

The Houthis have not renounced their earlier target set. Since 2023 they have claimed attacks on well over a hundred vessels linked to Israel, the United States and the United Kingdom, and that affiliation continues to carry risk independent of the Saudi dimension. Vessels with Israeli ownership, management, cargo or port-call history, and US or UK naval or commercial links, remain exposed throughout the Red Sea and Gulf of Aden.

Mistaken identity: the exposure for unaffiliated shipping



The most important point for operators of vessels with no obvious affiliation is that the Houthi targeting process is imperfect. During the 2024 crisis, vessels were struck on the basis of out-of-date ownership or commercial affiliations that no longer reflected their actual employment. The same risk applies now: a vessel with a historic Saudi, Israeli or Western commercial link in its record, or one whose AIS profile, flag, name or management resembles a targeted vessel, can be engaged in error. Trident assesses the mistaken-identity risk to genuinely unaffiliated vessels transiting the southern Red Sea as a credible and material one, and not a remote contingency.

The land targets: Yanbu, Jizan and the export corridor

The July strikes extended the threat from vessels to the fixed energy infrastructure on which the Saudi Red Sea export corridor depends. Two locations are central, and they carry very different strategic weight.

Yanbu

Yanbu, on the Red Sea coast north of Jeddah, is the western terminus of the East-West (Petroline) pipeline and the principal outlet for Saudi crude following the closure of Hormuz. Its North and South terminals load the majority of the crude reaching the Red Sea coast, and it hosts the SAMREF and YASREF refineries, with a combined capacity of around 800,000 barrels per day. Yanbu handles a volume of crude equivalent to a significant share of global supply, and it is, in effect, Saudi Arabia's remaining strategic export valve. The 25 July strike on Yanbu was the first in more than four years and, while the reported damage was limited, its significance is that the corridor's single most important node is now a demonstrated target.

The consequence for shipping is concentrated. Tankers loading at Yanbu, or waiting at anchorage for a berth, lie in proximity to infrastructure the Houthis have shown both the intent and the capability to strike. This produces a collateral-damage exposure to vessels at the port that is distinct from the risk of a deliberate strike on the vessel itself, and it is a material component of the elevated risk rating for the northern Saudi ports now within the Listed Area.

Jizan

Jizan (also rendered Jazan), close to the Yemeni border in the far south of the Saudi Red Sea coast, hosts an Aramco refinery of around 400,000 barrels per day. Its proximity to Houthi launch areas makes it the most exposed major facility on the coast; the 25 July strike set the refinery ablaze and led Aramco to suspend operations there. For shipping, the southern location is the critical factor: vessels calling at Jizan and the nearby terminal of Al Shuqaiq must transit the highest-threat segment of the southern Red Sea, close to the Yemeni coast and within easy reach of the full Houthi weapons inventory. The war risk premium increases have been sharpest for precisely these southern voyages.

The strategic picture

The wider significance is that the Houthis are pursuing a dual-chokepoint strategy. With Hormuz already closed, pressure on the Bab el-Mandeb and the Yanbu corridor threatens Saudi Arabia's last major export route. Around 7 to 9 per cent of global seaborne oil transits the Bab el-Mandeb, and every barrel leaving Yanbu must pass through it or divert north through the Suez Canal, which constrains the largest tankers, or around the Cape of Good Hope at an additional 10 to 14 days and well over a million dollars per voyage. The Houthi objective is not necessarily to close the strait physically, which they may lack the capacity to sustain, but to make owners and underwriters believe that specific vessels can be hit. In that narrower objective they have already succeeded.

Operating picture and outlook

Traffic through the Bab el-Mandeb fell by around 24 per cent in the days after the blockade declaration, with the disruption concentrated in the tanker sector, before stabilising. Saudi crude exports are continuing through workarounds, including lighter loadings at Yanbu, partial discharge at Egypt's Ain Sukhna to meet Suez draught limits, and use of the Sumed pipeline to bypass the canal. Wider commercial traffic has so far been less affected than the tanker trades, and industry behaviour has not yet shifted decisively.



That equilibrium is fragile. Trident assesses that a small number of further events, in particular the loss of a vessel or crew, a confirmed mistaken-identity strike on unaffiliated tonnage, or a sustained Houthi ability to hit tankers at or near Yanbu, would be sufficient to trigger larger-scale diversions and a further step-change in premiums. The Saudi-led coalition's strikes on Hodeidah and the proposed Red Sea security coalition unveiled at the end of July may constrain Houthi capability over time, but they also raise the risk of a retaliatory escalation in the near term.

For owners, charterers and their advisers, the practical consequences are already concrete: the northward expansion of the Listed Area brings Jeddah and Yanbu calls within the additional-premium and notification regime; breach-of-warranty and additional-premium exposure now attaches to a far larger set of Saudi voyages; and the mistaken-identity risk means that a clean current affiliation is not, by itself, a guarantee of safe passage.

Trident risk ratings

Exposure	Rating	Basis
Saudi-affiliated tankers, southern Red Sea / Bab el-Mandeb	CRITICAL	Declared blockade, demonstrated strikes, highest weapons exposure
Saudi-flagged/owned/operated vessels and Saudi port calls	SEVERE	Primary declared target set; strikes confirmed
Israel / US / UK-affiliated vessels, Red Sea and Gulf of Aden	SEVERE	Standing target set since 2023; capability intact
Vessels at Yanbu / Jizan (at berth or anchorage)	SEVERE	Collateral exposure to demonstrated strikes on port infrastructure
Unaffiliated vessels, southern Red Sea transit	ELEVATED	Mistaken-identity and proximity risk; not a remote contingency

Ratings use the Trident five-tier scale: LOW (an attack is highly unlikely), MODERATE (possible but not likely), ELEVATED (a credible possibility), SEVERE (likely), CRITICAL (highly likely or occurring). This assessment reflects the position as at 13 August 2026 and will be updated as the situation develops.

How Trident supports operators in the Red Sea

Trident provides maritime intelligence and risk advisory services to owners, charterers, insurers and their legal advisers operating in and around high-risk areas. In the current Red Sea environment this includes vessel-specific transit risk assessments and affiliation screening to identify mistaken-identity exposure before a voyage; monitoring of the Joint War Committee Listed Areas and their premium and notification implications; incident attribution and post-casualty assessment; and expert analysis to support war risk, charterparty and insurance matters. To discuss a specific voyage, fixture or exposure, contact the Trident intelligence team.

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